

FINANCIALLY AUTONOMOUS LOCAL GOVERNMENTS AS A SECURITY MULTIPLIER IN NORTH-CENTRAL NIGERIA

A Policy Scenario for AVM Morgan's North-Central Security Presentation

Imagine a North-Central state where every elected Local Government Chairman has full and transparent financial authority over the resources legally allocated to the local government, with strong auditing, public reporting and clear performance obligations. The security effect could be transformative.

What Changes at the Local Level

Security becomes local, not distant. The chairman knows the communities, difficult terrain, vulnerable settlements, schools, markets and emerging threats. He can respond to local problems without waiting for the state capital.

Early warning becomes stronger. Each LG can establish structured relationships with traditional rulers, community leaders, vigilantes, farmers, transport unions and other local stakeholders. Suspicious movements, kidnappings and communal tensions can therefore be reported much earlier.

Rapid response improves. Within lawful responsibilities, an LG could quickly provide logistics — vehicles, communications, emergency support, access roads, lighting and other basic infrastructure — to complement the police, civil defence and other security agencies.

Kidnapping becomes harder to sustain. Better local roads, lighting, community intelligence and functioning local institutions reduce the ability of criminal groups to operate invisibly and exploit neglected communities.

Youth recruitment into crime can decline. A financially functional LG can invest directly in skills, markets, agriculture, sports, sanitation and employment-generating programmes. Security is not only about weapons; it is also about reducing the pool of vulnerable young people available to criminal networks.

Scaling Up: All Six North-Central States

Now imagine all six North-Central states doing the same — Benue, Kogi, Kwara, Nasarawa, Niger and Plateau — operating with genuinely

empowered and accountable LG administrations. You would begin to create a six-state network of financially empowered local communities.

The chain could look like: *Federal Government → State Government → Autonomous/Accountable LG → Community → Security Agencies*

Instead of security information moving slowly from the village to the LG, to the state capital and eventually to Abuja, local governments could become the first institutional layer of prevention and early warning.

Cumulative Effect

1. Stronger community intelligence
2. Faster identification of emerging conflicts
3. Better support for conventional security agencies
4. Improved rural infrastructure
5. Reduced youth vulnerability to criminal recruitment
6. Greater government presence in remote communities
7. More accountability for security-related expenditure
8. Reduced dependence on ad-hoc emergency interventions

The Bigger Picture

If all North-Central LGs were financially empowered and properly audited, the region could effectively develop a bottom-up security architecture. The governor would no longer be expected to personally control every development and security intervention. His role would increasingly become that of strategic coordinator, standard-setter and supervisor, while the LG chairman becomes the government's operational face at the grassroots.

The Critical Caveat

Financial autonomy alone will not produce security. Without transparent procurement, independent auditing, competent LG administrations and close coordination with the Police, NSCDC, military and intelligence agencies, autonomy could simply decentralise corruption.

**Financial Autonomy + Accountability + Local Intelligence
+ Responsive Governance + Professional Security
Coordination = Stronger Grassroots Security**

A Powerful Conclusion for the Presentation

“If one local government is empowered, it can respond to a community. If every local government in a state is empowered, the state acquires a grassroots security network. But if all local governments across the six North-Central states are empowered, accountable and connected, we begin to build a regional security shield — one that prevents insecurity from taking root rather than merely responding after lives and property have been lost.”